

Migration Stories

How can we tell powerful stories about human migration?

Grades

4-8

Subjects

ELA, Social Studies

Estimated Duration

30-34 instructional
hours (across ELA &
Social Studies)

Key Content

narrative and
summary writing,
immigration, human
migration, history



Everyone living in the United States has a migration story somewhere in their family history, though we may not know our family's individual stories—many families' stories have been lost or interrupted due to the circumstances of their migration, particularly in cases of forced or involuntary migration. In this project, students study past migration events to and within the United States to gain the background information necessary for writing historically accurate stories that reflect the diverse realities of migration.

Project Path

Project Launch

What is it like to migrate from a place that is known to a place that is unknown?

Launch inquiry with a guest speaker who shares their migration story.

Build Knowledge and Develop & Critique

Why did people migrate to and within the United States in the past?

Identify and analyze the different reasons people have historically moved to and around the United States.

How will we structure our stories?

Learn about story structure and analyze how authors blend historical facts and narrative style to write historical narratives.

Who and what historical events will be featured in our stories?

Use historical information, character traits, and a character map to develop the plot and story's main character.

How can we write an engaging and accurate human migration story for elementary students?

Turn historical events into a historical narrative for elementary students.

Present Products

How can we share our stories with a wider audience?

Share children's books with elementary buddies, then record and post stories.

Make It Yours

Reflect on your students

- Are the materials and examples selected for the immigration project culturally sensitive and inclusive to ensure that no cultural or ethnic group feels misrepresented?
- How can you engage families in the project, taking into account that some families may have personal experiences with immigration?
- How can you be sensitive to the fact that some students and/or their families may be undocumented, and consequently may not want to share details about their own experiences?
- Have you created a safe and supportive classroom environment that recognizes the sensitivity and potential emotions associated with the topic of immigration?

Reflect on your context

- How will you be sure to highlight the importance of respecting and celebrating differences, conveying that diversity is a valuable aspect of society?
- How might guest speakers with personal immigration experiences or organizing field trips to cultural institutions related to immigration to provide real-world connections?
- Are there museums or cultural institutions in the area that could serve as field trip destinations?
- What immigrant communities are predominant in your local community? How can you be sure to include those stories in this project?

Reflect on the content & skills

- What are the language proficiency levels of your students? What scaffolds will need to be put into place for English language learners?

- In what ways can you foster critical thinking by encouraging students to ask questions, analyze information, and form their own opinions?
- What past experiences do students have with conducting interviews? What additional lessons need to be added to the project plan if students have never conducted interviews before?

Take It Further

Here are some ideas for expanding this project if you choose to do so:

- Have students record on sticky notes historical information about migration events and experiences they learn through reading literature. Sticky notes include the name of the story and page number on which the information is found and are shared with the project team following the specific group's migration journey.
- Take a trip to a local grocery store and note Foods from Far Away (https://amhistory.si.edu/ourstory/pdf/immigration/immigration_food.pdf). Discuss which far away foods have become local favorites. Share family recipes that have family immigration connections.
- Add activities to the project from PBS Learning Media's Great States (<https://wgvu.pbslearningmedia.org/collection/great-states/>) collection to deepen student understanding of local immigration experiences.
- Incorporate activities and lessons from the Smithsonian's Re-Imagining Migration (<https://learninglab.si.edu/collections/student-activity-an-exploration-of-immigration-migration-experiences/amM6Wp9K57o39Hn3#r/643191>) collection.
- Invite students to write, "Today I Am Here (<https://learninglab.si.edu/collections/student-activity-an-exploration-of-immigration-migration-experiences/amM6Wp9K57o39Hn3#r/643191>)," stories of their immigration or migration experience.
- Have students research and present information about various cultural celebrations related to immigration.
- Allow students to express their understanding of immigration through art. This could include creating paintings, sculptures, or collages that represent the emotions, challenges, or celebrations associated with immigration.

- Connect the project to the local community by inviting guest speakers, such as immigrants or representatives from cultural organizations, to share their stories and experiences with the students.
- Have students write letters to pen pals in other regions or countries, sharing their understanding of immigration and asking about the experiences of their peers.

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